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Author(s): Caroline Dyer, Archana Choksi, Vinita Awasty, Uma Iyer, Renu Moyade, Neerja Nigam and Neetu Purohit

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Democratising Teacher Education Research in India

CAROLINE DYER & ARCHANA CHOKSI with VINITA AWASTY, UMA IYER, RENU MOYADE, NEERJA NIGAM & NEETU PUROHIT

ABSTRACT *This paper argues for the need to adopt a more participatory and research-based approach to teacher development in India. Drawing on the experiences of a participatory teacher educator development project in three States, we discuss processes of developing a democratically orientated qualitative research team to work with teachers and teacher educators, highlighting the interplay between their education and socialisation and the demands of the methodology. In the second part of the paper, aspects of developing collaborative action research projects with teacher educators in the context of District Institutes of Education and Training are discussed. Both these approaches require the development of autonomy and critical reflexivity, and although there are tensions in this process, these emerge as vital components of developing a more democratic approach to teacher education.*

Teacher Education in India: the need for a more democratic approach

A key rationale for the current focus on decentralisation in educational reforms in India is the need to facilitate the development of a more responsive, inclusive and democratic educational system. These reforms, notably the District Primary Education Programme, have begun to challenge the established centralised system of educational management by strengthening managerial capacity at the District level. Although new institutional structures of teacher education have also been established in the Districts, the formal teacher education programmes they offer continue to follow a top-down approach, and are mostly devised and funded at the State or even national level, following the internationally dominant ‘skills- and knowledge-based’ approach (Hargreaves & Fullan, 1992, p. 2; NCTE, 1998c). Such processes of teacher development are profoundly undemocratic, since they overlook the possibility of involving teachers as equals in programme development, even though they are central to the success of the proposed change—a curious phenomenon that persists in many educational systems (Villegas-Reimers & Reimers, 1996; Dyer, 1996). There is equally little evidence in India of teacher educators being involved in programme design or policy processes.

The lack of teacher and teacher educator voices in decision-making processes in India is an important factor in a striking gap between the expectations of and about teachers articulated in policy discourses (e.g. the National Policy on Education [NPE] 1986/92), and situations on the ground in the schools (cf. PROBE, 1999; Dyer, 1999, 2000). The

Correspondence to: Caroline Dyer, School of Education, Oxford Road, Manchester M13 9PL, UK. Email: Caroline.Dyer@man.ac.uk

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‘ecological validity’ (Hargreaves & Fullan, 1992) of teacher education has long been recognised as weak, as official documents at the national level, three decades apart, acknowledge:

The syllabi used in training institutions are quite old and outdated. New items have been added to existing syllabi bit by bit. They do not cater to the needs of future teachers. [...] There should be a balance between theory and practice. (NCERT, 1970, p. 117)

The system still prepares teachers who do not necessarily become professionally competent and committed at the completion of initial teacher preparation programmes. (NCTE, 1998a, p. 5)

The current head of the apex National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE) has also noted that the quality of teacher education programmes has been ‘a consistent concern’, as they are ‘confined to classroom transaction strategies, some theoretical inputs and a few skills [...]’. The teacher–learner relationship becomes trivialised’ (Rajput & Walia, 1998, pp. 146–147).

The need to craft new, more inclusive and inherently democratic approaches to teacher education in India is evident. In this paper we focus on the democratising opportunities offered by a research-based, collaborative approach to teacher educator development which we adopted for a two and a half year project in three States (Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan). Dyer and Choksi, as the team leaders, designed a research approach that was rooted in the interpretive research paradigm, using a combination of qualitative methods and participatory action research with teacher educators. Both research modes fall outside the prevalent model in India, and the project offered a framework within which we could explore doing research in a more democratic and egalitarian way than is usually found in India. We opted for a qualitative methodology because it offers the methodological scope to probe and illuminate the complex social realities in which teaching and learning are embedded, which would help in our intention of understanding how the ecological validity of teacher education might be improved. We also felt that this project could open up exciting new democratic possibilities if it deliberately adopted a participatory approach, attempting to work ‘with’ rather than ‘on’ or ‘about’ teachers and their educators, and so bring research and practitioners much closer together.

Educational Research in India

To contextualise the need for our approach, we begin with a brief overview about the general research climate in education in India. Very little educational research in India adopts a qualitative methodology (Choksi & Dyer, 1997): the positivist paradigm continues to dominate although there are signs of change as universities’ faculties of education and social sciences begin to teach qualitative methods (e.g. Delhi University and the Maharaja Sayaji Rao University in Vadodara, Gujarat). The situation in India reflects a research climate that is widely found in the developing world (see, for example, Mwiria, 1996 for a discussion of similar issues in East Africa; and Crossley & Vulliamy, 1997). Raina (2001), analysing contributions to the *Indian Educational Review* (IER), one of India’s leading educational journals, of which he was editor at the time of writing, notes that over the last three decades, survey, experimental methods and content analysis have constituted 85% of all studies, and that ‘the preferred investigative methods have been those grounded in a quantitative, positivistic paradigm’ (Raina, 2001, p. 120). The research community remains predominantly male: only 24% of the researchers in his sample were female (Raina, 2001, p. 124). He also comments that ‘educational research in India is still greatly influenced by the study of various psychological processes [...] the fact remains that the exploration of issues relating to

educational research in its socio-cultural, economic and historical contexts has remained comparatively unattempted' (Raina, 2001, p. 118).

Mishra's (1999) discussion also sheds helpful light on aspects of the prevailing research climate that in his view contribute to poor quality research. He argues that the government is 'interested in supporting researchers who can deliver quick results' and that consequently 'serious' researchers 'consider such research highly superficial' (Mishra, 1999, p. 343). Additional funds now available as a result of bi-lateral and international agency support have, he claims, reinforced a tendency towards fund-chasing where 'even sub-standard proposals are approved and funded simply because money is available' (Mishra, 1999, p. 343). Funding is more likely to be available for commissioned research, while research that develops out of a researcher's own initiative is less likely to find funding, particularly if the proposer does not have an established research reputation or is not 'known to people at the funding agencies' (Mishra, 1999, p. 344). In sum:

Entering upon a research enterprise is an invitation to recurrent, frustrating experiences [...]. Research carried out with respect to primary and secondary education in India presents a gloomy picture [...]. Researchers have not been successful in responding to today's educational challenges. They need to work seriously towards finding 'economically viable' and 'ecologically valid' modes of education for various groups of Indian society. (Mishra, 1999, p. 345)

Current educational arrangements tend to serve poorly, or exclude altogether, social groups who do not fit into existing models (cf. Mishra's 1999 discussion of tribal groups; Dyer's 1999 discussion of nomads). The notion that all children should go to school, enshrined in the Indian Constitution and affirmed again at Jomtien in 1990 and Dakar in 2000, is part of the discourse of equality in the world's largest democratic polity. In this respect, enhancing the responsiveness of educational research in India might be seen as a democratising strategy, in that it can increase our understandings of how to promote and serve the educational needs of all citizens and thus support the emergence of a more just, more egalitarian and democratic society.

Alongside this, there is a need also to extend the boundaries of educational research, beyond the limitations of the existing positivist paradigm, so that it too becomes more democratic and inclusive. Qualitative, participatory research in itself offers interesting possibilities, and perhaps the more so if it is linked into an internationally comparative approach, as Mishra (1999) suggests: 'Co-operation with researchers working in other multi-lingual and multi-cultural societies will be highly rewarding in respect of designing research on Indian educational processes' (p. 346).

However, any attempt to do this will inevitably have to engage with the cross-cultural issues that are involved in applying methodologies deriving from a particular set of social circumstances in new contexts. Part of our intention in the following sections is to illuminate some of the underlying assumptions of these approaches as they were applied within this research project, and to draw out the implications for a more democratic approach to both educational research, and teacher education.

We begin by setting the institutional context of our research—the District Institutes of Education and Training (DIETs)—and how the research approach we adopted in the three State study evolved from a small case study of one DIET. The following section focuses on the development of the research team, describing how the new Indian team members learned to do qualitative research and presenting their reflections about this experience of a democratic approach to research within the cross-cultural project team. In the subsequent section,

we discuss the participatory action research projects with teacher educators, which were supported by the project research team.

Qualitative and Participatory Research with DIETs

Developing An Alternative Research Approach for Teacher Education

The District Institutes of Education and Training (DIETs) were one component of a scheme for the restructuring and revitalisation of teacher education which arose from the 1986/92 National Policy on Education. As part of the larger movement towards decentralisation of educational management, DIETs were charged with improving the responsiveness of training programmes to teacher's training needs. Each District would have one DIET, consisting of seven branches, which would train pre- and in-service teachers, pursue curricular innovations, and plan and manage educational development. In addition, the DIET should undertake 'action research and experimentation to deal with specific problems of the district in achieving the objectives in the areas of elementary and adult education' (MHRD, 1989, p. 8). The mandate of the DIET itself both explicitly and implicitly requires this institute to engage in research, or at least some kind of evaluation of educational processes in classrooms, in order to make teacher training more responsive.

Dyer and Choksi began explorations of teacher education with a case study of one DIET in Gujarat in 1997. This revealed several aspects of teacher education that not only the researchers, but also the DIET staff felt were problematic—most particularly that training messages were having a limited impact on classroom practices. This case study partly followed the traditional linear model of research, in which researchers create knowledge that is then disseminated, to the extent that it yielded 'policy advice'—albeit advice that was grounded in in-depth observation and discussions with teacher educators. DIET staff are used to such linear research, and to the positivistic conceptualisation of research as being 'on' or 'about' subjects—so those involved in a research project are divided into those who are assumed to have the technical, research expertise (the research team) and those who are its subjects (or objects)—the 'respondents'. Our approach differed in that we tried to work with teacher educators on constructive problematisation of issues they raised. This began a process of dialogue that seemed to offer new possibilities for change since, as Freire (1970) suggests, dialogue is multi-directional and reflects a stance towards knowledge that is quite different from that embedded in the positivist paradigm. The dialoguing stance values those working at the 'chalk face' and assumes they have a contribution to make in setting both direction and pace of processes of change, as Carasco *et al.* (2001) suggest: 'By seeing one another as potential creators and users of knowledge, researchers, policy makers, and practitioners may penetrate traditional barriers—status, language, and class differences—to communication. This presents a more participatory view in which everyone in the system has much to learn about reaching the ambitious goals for student learning' (p. 258).

It was with this conviction that Dyer and Choksi initiated a larger research project, working with six DIETs across three States, and a team of Indian researchers who had not undertaken qualitative research before. This project had two key strands, which were iterative. One was an ethnographic take on events, done by the research team to provide a situation analysis of the DIET and its relationship with schools and educational management in its District. The second strand, the professional development of the DIET staff, was initiated through collaborative action research projects which offered opportunities to reflect critically on working practices (see Dyer, Choksi *et al.*, 2002).

The Research Team: towards autonomy, critical reflexivity and a democratic approach

This project integrated the professional development of the new researchers with the data generation process, so that the team's learning about doing qualitative research in the context of a more democratic way of working than they had previously encountered became part of the research project in its own right. In this section, we highlight aspects of that learning process, in particular the interplay between the new team members' education and socialisation and the demands of the methodology. The research team consisted of six local researchers, coincidentally female and younger than 30, each of whom was attached to one DIET and came from the State in which she was employed; the Project Manager (Indian) and Director (British); and support staff. None of the new researchers had had practical experience of qualitative research; and none of them had been inside a DIET. The initial processes of team building took place during an intensive one week training programme and we held five day workshops every two months after that, in addition to visits by the project leaders to the sites, and telephone and e-mail communications. Although the initial preparation was intensive, it was inevitable that the new researchers would experience a steep learning curve once they entered the field:

Like all of us, qualitative research was something new. I had never done anything like that. I had some research experience but that was of a different kind. (NN, 27/5/00)

Not only was this the first time they had done research of this type; for most of the team members it was also a first experience of working in rural areas, and of state-managed primary schools:

When I went to the training programme, I was alone, there was nothing, no toilets, nothing. I was the only woman among all those teachers. It was a village. It was the first time in my life I had seen a village. They were bringing water from the well and all that... (NP, 26/5/00)

So today I was fully prepared to go (and) reached Begliawas by 11.10, found a private bus goes to (village) at about 11.45 so sat there, but the bus came at 12.20. The villagers sitting under the tree asked me about me and my profession, I told them and asked them if they know any good teacher. A villager said that earlier there was one teacher X, who was OK. But he has gone and now the teachers are all rubbish, do nothing except ask for money now and again, either 20 or 10 [...]. Just then, bus came, it is quite interior [remote], but the bus stopped in front of the school. I was really scared—what if I don't get a return bus. Got out, some boys [18–20 year old] were sitting near the boundary. The first thing I heard was 'beautiful' and giggling—I thought I might have just been a fool to come here all alone. Anyway went into the school, found all classes sitting on the ground in the open with teachers. (NP, 11/12/99)

I hadn't seen a village before so in the beginning when I went to those remote villages I used to wonder where I had come. I used to wonder what would happen—I may not reach back home today. After doing it many times it became routine. (NN, 27/5/00)

All team members concurred that one of the positive benefits of the research was a broadening of horizons, as they went into contexts they had never before experienced.

One of the training messages in the initial and subsequent workshops was that being a good qualitative researcher goes far beyond the simple application of methods. With their

background in the prevailing positivist mode, the research team at first understood their job mostly in terms of ‘collecting’ data, as if the data were ready-made and there to be found and filed away:

In the beginning, at least what I used to do, was to collect the data and forget about it, about what I had done. I could not relate to it [...] what we used to do was to ask one question after another. Asked a question, either taped it or wrote and asked the next question. (NN, 28/5/00)

We used to feel one thing is over, now let’s get on with the second one. (NP, 27/5/00)

This approach led to a proliferation of data—a ‘collection’ on file—of which the researchers themselves became critical as they gained more experience. We were all dissatisfied with these ‘once off’ interviews and observations, which led to a vast collection of superficial data, and an unmanageable backlog of untranscribed tapes and observation notes. With a lot of encouragement from the project leaders, the researchers became increasingly reflexive about their own research processes.

It’s very frightening to see all that data! That’s why I will say data management is very important, because if you don’t do that you won’t be able to think. [...] there was no direction to the work. That way Caroline’s December workshop was very useful when she told us about relating to our data, to see if there is a further link. After that I started doing it... I started reflecting. I realised my work is not just to go there, collect data, report it, send it and then it’s all over, and forget about it. (NN, 28/5/00)

Greater sensitivity to the ‘give and take’ nature of qualitative research in turn led to reflections on their own qualities both as a questioner, and as a listener:

I used to go the field with great excitement and I never thought my questioning style was an important issue. I used to feel if he is answering that is good, so I didn’t pay any attention to my questioning skills. The way we ask questions is very important and we should document that too. I used to get so excited that I couldn’t see or hear the direction in which someone was talking to me. I just used to ask the questions I wanted to ask, one by one, whatever I wanted to ask; and would write whatever he answered and go. We didn’t get their perceptions or what each person was thinking. (RM, 28/5/00)

We were not listening. We were not active listeners. Listening was far from our minds, in our minds it was like question one, two, three. What we should have done was develop conversations from whatever answer we were getting. But what did we do? They are saying we do this or this training, and this and this happened, and they are telling their experiences, but instead of listening to the experiences we tell them ‘that’s OK but after that what training did you give here?’ Because that was the questioning order. That happened a lot so what happened was our interviews were very short and in-depth details which should have been there didn’t come. It was all very shallow and superficial. So it’s very important to listen. Questioning is OK, you have to question, but ‘listen!’. Listen to their talk and based on that, you question. If you are going to meet someone, keep in mind the points you want to cover. But have it in mind also that you don’t cut the conversation to cover your points... Now I have started listening and I don’t go there with my shopping list of questions. (NN, 28/5/00)

Efforts moved away from ‘collecting’ data, toward ‘generating’ them—a term that more accurately reflects the idea that data are created as a result of human interaction. With this, the pattern of work changed as less time was spent in the field, and more time was spent on recording accurately interviews and observations, and reflecting on what had gone on in order to plan the future:

You take observations or interview, when you observe you get points for interviews—so it’s a link, it’s a cycle which will go on. (RM, 26/5/00)

You have to plan, like today I did an interview, today I felt this and this, and came across these and these problems. In that a process comes ... you took an interview so you reflect on the process itself. Then what was the method? During the interview something wasn’t coming out, what did I do about that? You can’t write about that in the interview, but it goes in the diary. After that you might feel yes I did this interview but these things are still left which I need to confirm or if I talk to another few people it will be clarified. So your planning will come, the reflection on your process will also come. And the work which is going on, how did you do it? The whole method also comes in the diary. (NN, 26/5/00)

The research journals became more mature, changing from reporting what they had done to include a vital component of reflection.

In a diary your first feelings are reflected. I didn’t have any idea what a diary is and I avoided writing it because I didn’t have any idea what to write [...]. I didn’t know diary means reflection. What I learned from diaries is also analysing myself. Now since I have started writing one, I enjoy writing it more than observation, because I think twice—a thinking process. It starts your thinking process [...]. As soon as you start writing a diary you immediately start thinking what will happen next? What should be done next? Like, you start planning for yourself. (VA, 28/5/00)

Looking back on her journal keeping, one researcher lamented:

I never put into the diary—which I should have done—things like I got angry or frustrated ... why are they doing it this way or why are three bodies working this way or why don’t you ask teachers what you do in the classroom? Why do you start with your own themes? Why don’t you let teachers be free and tell them ‘we would like you to do this’ and ask teachers how they might do it? Here you are dumping on teachers ‘do it this way’. All these things which I am reflecting on now I should have put in my diary but I didn’t do that ... If you put it all in the diary from the beginning it will help you later ... I didn’t realise at that time that they [A and C] also wanted to know what’s going on in my mind. (NP, 28/5/00)

In this process, with encouragement, they began to take ownership of the direction of the research project, rather than seeing their role as passing data ‘upwards’ to the project leaders and receiving instructions in return. The lines of accountability were still clear, but increasingly the responsibility for data generation was devolved to the researchers, who were better placed to know their local situations. As one of them said, ‘For us it was a new culture in which we were accountable for everything’ (RM, 28/5/00). The team leaders tried to offer support and to help the researchers by drawing out of de-briefing sessions aspects which seemed to merit more detailed investigation, and make suggestions about how this might be done. During the workshops when we all met together, each researcher would present her situation analysis for discussion and critique by her peers, which helped strengthen the research at the individual sites as well as generate cross-site comparison.

Reflections on Developing a Democratic Research Approach

The foregoing account gives a sense of some of the processes involved in learning to do qualitative research, and sketches out how the researchers grew into a much more democratic way of working than they had been used to. The greatest challenges were the exacting demands of high levels of personal autonomy and critical reflexivity, and this drew further analysis of some of the tensions operating at an individual level as one tries to adopt a more democratic working style. At a personal level the researchers all felt, whatever difficulties they had had to face, that the project had given them an opportunity to develop which they valued very highly:

I must say one thing, through the project you have to interact with so many people that you really get confident. After a year you will feel you could go anywhere and talk to anyone [...]. This is a very big thing which you develop, at least I have developed it. (NN, 26/5/00)

An unstated assumption of the project was that knowledge is not so much a series of scientific facts to be learned and regurgitated in exams, but something that is socially constructed—and hence one of the tasks of the research was to understand how teachers and teacher educators construct their knowledge. This was a fundamentally challenging aspect of the research project for the team members who had grown up in the dominant Indian culture of schooling, which adheres to a notion of ‘hard’ knowledge, and their move away from collection towards generation of data reflects the emergence of the alternative stance to knowledge embedded in the research project.

Another challenge, going hand in hand with the stance of knowledge, was learning to be comfortable with the sort of critical questioning that is essential to the qualitative research process. The Indian researchers had all been socialised, both in their own schooling and family contexts, to avoid such a stance:

One of the things we should always think about is what kind of culture we have come from. If we think about it, we were faced with one very big thing: that we never get this kind of initiative to do something. We live in the classroom culture. Even after we come out of that classroom culture we never ask questions of our brains, we never ask questions of our elders, we don’t say to our parents ‘why are you telling me something like this?’ We are taught this habit from school. [...] We are told ‘this is there, read it, remember it and do exams’. If you get marks you are very intelligent by writing the same things that are given in the text book. Get the marks, you pass and you are very intelligent. (RM, 28/5/00)

The question of hierarchies surfaced particularly strongly for one team member who had formerly worked locally for an international aid organisation. Reflecting on her first interview with a government official in her new capacity, she wrote:

I learned a lot about the behaviour of the government officials and their work pattern and style. It was a bit uncomfortable as I was losing my temper on some occasions when I thought why there was so much delay without any reason. But Archana and Caroline told me that it would not help me in the long run [...]. I really felt that it was not at all needed to lose patience. But when I retrospect, I think it was my previous experience in [international organisation] where I used to deal with the government officials and used to really get the work done by giving out needs and repercussions at the same time. Whereas here we wanted to wait and see what they felt and waited for them to come out with a response. Maybe earlier it was the product which mattered and here the process is more important. (UI, 13/4/99)

One of the issues team members raised with respect to improving educational quality was the question of accountability, which they linked with the absence of encouragement to be critical and autonomous:

In our house the TV is on no matter what film is going on. We might switch off the TV but we never tell the cable provider 'if you give something like this we are not going to pay you'. This accountability is never there in our system. We have to learn it. There is no accountability and no-one is ready to reflect or think in our system. We are supposed to work, we know how to work, and we work. What will be the end result of that or what prior preparation we need to do—all these things which come under professional development we don't understand at all. That's why we are answerable to no-one and we never ask anything of anyone—and if you do ask anyone why and how this happened usually they will try to escape, or they will try to push us away through other pressures. If a teacher says one day, we don't want this type of training and we won't go, why can't a revolution come here? Change will come. (RM, 28/5/00)

And as a culture we believe in centralised things not in decentralisation. In our families also the senior people have the authority—like, we are settled in a pattern of centralisation. (VA, 28/5/00)

These were crucial issues to juggle with for these young female researchers as they worked in the hierarchical and male-dominated DIETs, where they were generally at least ten years younger than the youngest staff member. The following comment captures a sense of the changed attitude to research processes, and to knowledge, that allowed the research team to be accepted enough to embark upon the action research and professional development strand of the project.

If you go there first and start saying this and that it will not work. You have to be accepted by them. Like them you have to go and sit there. You may feel what is it? We are just sitting here. You have to talk like them. You have to sit in the staffroom also. You have to participate in whatever discussions are going on—marriage, children, pickles, food, everything. All the social chat. If you go with just one aim, like, I have to work here, it will not happen. This way gradually you have to be accepted. [...] here you are not going just as a researcher, you are staying with them, you are becoming their friend, sometimes you help them too, sometimes you just go as a learner. You are learning from them. (NN, 29/5/00)

Research in the DIETs

This project was for all the DIETs a first experience of a more process-orientated research approach. Although, like the more linear research they had been used to, this study had also originated from an outside source, its intention was very different. We did not wish to gather data and report elsewhere, but to work with staff on using research to help with evaluating the effectiveness of training practices. Within this broad frame, the project design had a good deal of flexibility as it was intended to help DIETs develop their own research agenda and support them as they carried it out. The point of connection was the DIET mandate of doing action research, and the need DIETs acknowledged to develop their expertise in this area, for which they would take the project team's help. Even so, overcoming the external origination of the project idea to find ways of developing a meaningful partnership with each DIET remained a challenge which we could not always successfully meet. The proposed length of the project (two years) and the long-term presence of a researcher at the DIET were

unfamiliar possibilities. Another issue was that the project was not offering any inputs of physical equipment (such as new computers etc.) which DIETs felt would improve their efficiency, but concentrated on staff development and stressed the need to work co-operatively together to this end. We encountered varying degrees of openness towards these ideas and the extent to which DIETs 'bought in' to them, both initially and over the life of the project, which in turn shaped the impact the project had on each DIET.

It became increasingly clear as we worked together that recruitment to the DIETs is highly problematic (see also NCTE, 1998a, b). Post-graduate qualifications were set as the criteria for appointment, although these are usually held by people who originally elected to be secondary school teachers as primary teacher education takes place in colleges which award diplomas or teaching certificates. Most DIET staff have been recruited from the secondary sector and across our sites, hardly a handful had any primary teaching experience. It was also evident that the substantive areas of their degrees were not well linked to the requirements of the DIET posting: the holder of a Master's degree in Geography might for example be posted to the Planning and Management branch without any further training. Unfortunately, many staff had manipulated their posting to the DIET because it was personally convenient, rather than joining the DIET out of professional interest. Others were not there from their own volition, but because there are transferable postings between the secondary sector and the DIET:

AC How did you come to the DIET?

TT They pushed us. We got transferred. We didn't know what it [the DIET] was.
(MP/DHA, 21.6.99)

The situation was then compounded because nothing resembling an appropriate induction course for new staff members was in place, although Gujarat State was revising its arrangements to address this issue. Once in post, despite the poor fit between the qualifications for posting and the requirements of the job, there were no structured professional development opportunities for serving staff. The National Action Plan for Teacher Education also comments on this:

There is very little provision, if at all, for training and retraining of teacher educators. In fact teacher educators are by default and not by training since about all teacher educators in primary teacher training institutions possess a secondary teacher training certificate, and were trained to be a secondary school teacher. They too need training if the quality of primary teacher training—both pre-service and in-service—is to be improved. (NAP, 1996, p. 15)

Any opportunities that do exist take the form of occasional individual opportunities to take training at the State level as a Key Resource Person for new programmes, delivered at the District level via a training cascade. These opportunities are jealously protected, with the result that the same handful of people enjoyed this privilege while others rarely got even this chance to develop themselves. However, in each DIET, the research project was very much welcomed by a handful of staff who sought to develop themselves professionally, since this opportunity was otherwise not available:

We are working as practitioners. With you we will be able to share your experiences as educationalists and researchers. We will be able to share research experience and that's a big thing. This is our first need. We who are working in this faculty, for our own capacity-building there is nothing. We try to build our capacity and apply in the field. We learn from the people in the field and improve ourselves and again do it. Today this is the only thing we have for learning. Nothing else. (RAJ/MAS, January 1999)

In the three States in our study it had also proved very difficult to recruit DIET Principals. In the majority of our sites, the Vice-Principal was acting Principal. The V-P does not have the full administrative power granted to a Principal; and nor does s/he enjoy the full respect of colleagues who see her/him as being of equal rather than superior rank—a pretender to the seat, rather than its rightful occupant. DIET staff hold the Principal to be crucial in the effectiveness of a DIET:

NN how important is the Principal's role in the DIET?

TT The chair directs the whole DIET. The DIET works according to the chair. The initiation is always from the chair. If the chair looks forward, the DIET will move forward. If it looks backwards, the DIET goes backwards. (RAJ/UDR, June 1999)

This emphasis on the crucial importance of the Principal and sense that the institution has no possibility of functioning without one was unanimous across the States. The absence of a Principal impacted on the research project too, in the sense that no-one was properly responsible for leading the DIET, and thus for deciding whether and how the research project might be useful to it.

A further important aspect of the DIET's structuring which had many consequences for the research is the contested nature of decentralisation. Although a rationale for DIETs was increased local responsivity to teachers' training needs, they were officially conceived as the third, District-level tier of a top-down system that begins at the centre in New Delhi and then moves to the State level (MHRD, 1989). While physically located at the District level, the DIETs in our sample were highly centralised, their role limited mainly to the delivery of programmes designed and funded from the State (or national) level. This left the DIET staff in the position of having to carry out programmes that they know are not necessarily suitable for their teachers:

At present they give us a target and we have to finish that. It is completely useless. I can't do it till I get permission from the higher authorities ... At present we call [invite for training] them [teachers] to finish the target... There is no point in finishing targets. [Even] if we tell the government we have met our training programme target we will not be able to improve the quality of primary education. (MP/IND, February 1999)

You do whatever order comes from the top, give the training programme according to the time which is given to you. (MP/DHA, August 2000)

At the same time, this centralisation allowed the DIETs to locate much of the responsibility for their dissatisfaction in the activities of the State level, rather than reviewing the possibilities for initiating local amendments. After one year of working on the project, one research team member summed up the impact of these contextual factors on the DIET:

In the DIET there aren't the kind of people who have a powerful vision, who have creativity or flexibility. The thing about participation which was there couldn't come at all because the government developed so much infrastructure. It's like a white elephant [...] NCERT slowly started giving something to SCERT and SCERT started to give to the DIET. So everyone is looking up and no-one wants to use their brains.

The tensions in staffing, and in the design of the DIET which embodied conflicting pulls of centralisation and decentralisation, resulted in tensions for the institutes in developing the

levels of autonomy that are required for the DIET idea to make sense. Without this sense of autonomy, the more democratic approach to teacher development envisaged in the policy could not readily emerge.

Our starting point for collaboration was action research, which depends crucially on the notion of a teacher being a reflexive and expert practitioner, ready to engage in critical reflection on his/her own practices, and committed to making changes by taking action (e.g. Elliott, 1991; McNiff, 1991). Elliott (1991) argues that both a sense of agency and 'democratic intent' must underlie such commitment. One of the assumptions underpinning the action research approach is that it continues a dimension of practitioner activity that already exists, in that educators are assumed to be constantly reflecting on and adjusting their practices. This may be a rather idealised notion of the teacher even where levels of professionalism are much higher, but in India one of the main issues which we identified as a concern for teacher education was the lack of a self-reflexive stance among both teachers and their educators. Unsurprisingly, the prevalent view of action research among DIET staff was of small-scale projects which involved action, i.e. field work, but had no reflective component. These projects had usually been commissioned by the State level and the data were sent there; the research was rarely seen by DIET staff to connect with them.

Rajput & Walia (1998, p. 148) also note that the existing system of teacher education 'pays scant attention to self-motivated learning'. The more common tendency is to externalise 'problems' as emanating from the administration, parents, children, or distant curriculum designers. This allows teachers and educators who wish to do so to keep at arm's length ownership of these problems at the classroom level or responsibility for mediating between curriculum and context. To add to this, any action research project necessarily has to engage with practitioners' lack of a sense of their own agency. The linked tendency not to reflect and not to have a strong sense of agency presents quite a challenge to the democratic intentions underlying action research. Considerable prompting from the project team was required to consider that low teacher interest and motivation might not be simply wilful, but could be related to the quality/relevance of INSET provided by the DIET; or that teachers might not have understood the training messages; or that teachers might find it difficult to see how to implement a training idea in school.

The topics that were selected across the DIETs were on teachers' attitudes to change, transmission loss in the cascade model, and one DIET opted for action research on their time management (a full account of the collaborative action research projects is given in Dyer *et al.*, 2002). Although the action research projects yielded rich data on the chosen themes, engaging the DIET staff in this mode of enquiry was heavily conditioned by structural and staffing constraints. Action research is based on the assumption of a will to improve practices, and where educators have become used to externalising the locus of accountability for the quality of practices, as we found in these DIETs, this will cannot be taken for granted. The project demonstrated quite clearly that there is a need to cultivate and nurture this sense of accountability for any movement towards more democratic practices to take place; and that decentralisation does not have much of a chance of becoming anything other than token unless there is an investment in this process.

Another key aspect of self-reflexive praxis is the ability to problematise practice, and an action research cycle typically begins with 'problem identification'. In practice, it is very difficult to focus down through a web of interconnected concerns to a particular concern that is researchable; the DIET staff had no experience of talking about and sharing practice. Also, since most DIET staff did not visit the field and engage very closely with teachers, usually meeting them only in training programmes, their perception of problems with training was not informed by the evaluations of classroom processes that are needed to understand how

teacher development might start and what direction it should take. A sense of ownership of the need to take action at the District level was a pre-requisite for interest in undertaking action research: for some staff this was there from the outset; for others the possibilities of their role in the DIET became much clearer as a result of doing research; and others chose not to opt into participation in the research initiative.

This process of helping teachers to articulate, and reflect on, their own values and theories of practice, in turn brought challenges for the project team in sustaining democratic intent. A significant investment of time was required to create relationships of mutual trust, and to develop the 'research with' climate, without which disagreements over practice may be interpreted as fault-finding rather than constructive support. The workload of the DIET staff varied considerably: it was lightest in the DIETs which were overstaffed, or had been bypassed by the parallel structure of the District Primary Education Programme; and heaviest in those DIETs which were short-staffed but trying to run a full schedule of training programmes. Finding time for action research in a busy schedule is genuinely difficult, but here an underlying issue seemed not so much the busyness of staff, as the locus of accountability. If the team arranged a workshop but on the day an instruction came from the State level, the DIET staff would prioritise the State order, even if this was at the cost of the long-arranged research workshop. The government culture remains very much one of action governed by orders, and this clashed with the democratic intention of the research project which expected participation to take place on the basis of interest and availability. On quite a few occasions, thus, the DIET staff were diverted to arguably less relevant tasks than analysing and reflecting on the implications for their practices of the data generated by the action research projects.

These incidents reflected the extent to which, despite the discourse of decentralisation which provided a key rationale for setting up DIETs, centralisation is still a dominant feature of both the structural and perceptual landscapes in teacher education through these institutes. In addition to this systemic feature, it is hard for DIET staff to overcome their initial socialisation as a secondary teacher into a role of classroom controller rather than the learning facilitator envisaged in policy discourse. One researcher noted:

What I really feel is that people who have worked in secondary have a strong habit of controlling. One, they feel that their knowledge is much more than primary teachers'. They teach children and children never answer back so there is a huge ego in them, no-one can object to me. I can see all these things in the DIET very much. There they want to rule teachers during training. There is no participation there.

These two factors create tension in any process that aims, as our research did, to support a more democratic and locally-generated approach to improving the quality of teacher education at the local level. However, these tensions notwithstanding, the research did help many DIET staff amend their views of teachers towards a more positive stance, as they considered teachers' responses to their questions about changes and training programmes. Although for some DIET staff it remained more comfortable and familiar not to engage with what teachers were saying to them, for others the action research projects furnished useful insights which led to immediate changes to their practices.

Towards More Democratic Teacher Education Research

The two accounts above have demonstrated how this research project provided a framework for adopting qualitative and participatory approaches to educational research in teacher education. In both contexts, the development of autonomy and critical reflexivity were crucial

factors in the emergence of a more democratic *modus operandi*. The research team was able to operate in a decentralised way, with support to each member in developing autonomy and reflexive, critical thinking about her own practice as she engaged in research with teachers and their educators. In the DIETs, where decentralisation had yet to become an operational and perceptual reality, it was much more difficult to create a context supportive of the development of such an approach, particularly since the research team and the action research projects could not be fully incorporated into the DIET functioning. Although the collaborations with the DIETs were able to make small beginnings, there were many limitations to what we could do. Some of the DIET staff themselves felt almost imprisoned by their circumstances, as one researcher noted:

The question which re-surfaced about how the project could help the sinking ship is to be addressed seriously. I think there is this feeling [among DIET staff] that what and how the project will take away the woes of the DIET. (UI, 16/9/99)

The research project was reasonably successful in modelling a more democratic approach in the way we operated as a team, which was discussed and commented upon positively in DIETs. Our collaborative approach to doing research, in which we tried to value people's different roles and experiences and draw positively on them, also offered an alternative to the hierarchical ordering of the DIET. These were small but important beginnings, but they took place within a wider context that remains hierarchical and centralised, rather than decentralised and democratic. Our research suggests that the DIETs are not likely to play a very effective part in democratising teacher education unless they are restructured—recruiting staff who opt into these posts for appropriate professional reasons, and are supported in developing their technical expertise and professional attitudes—and there is a willingness by apex bodies to give substance to the democratic premise of decentralisation by moving much more firmly towards support and facilitation rather than control.

The uses of qualitative and participatory approaches in researching teacher education seem to offer a significant alternative to the positivist paradigm. One teacher, working with the DIET staff on an action research project, summed up the essence of this difference:

We have filled in so many questionnaires by those university professors. They get someone to come and he just ticks the boxes. It never makes any difference to us. But the way you have been asking us questions, asking us to write our opinions ... you have made us think for the first time. (anon questionnaire response)

The inherent methodological stress on the development of autonomy and critical reflexivity offers those working within this paradigm the opportunity to *engage* with their own practices in a way that has not previously been required. While these notions, borrowed from very different professional contexts, are difficult to embed into teacher education in India at present, we believe that such engagement is a pre-requisite for real change. The prevailing approach to teacher development, which relies on top-down directives, neglects the importance of such engagement and its seminal contribution to the genuine democratisation of teacher education. We remain cautiously optimistic about the democratising possibilities of the research-led approach we adopted, and the many opportunities that exist for future researchers, teacher educators and teachers to work on fine-tuning such an approach to individual local educational contexts. We are, however, left with little doubt that systemic reforms need to become more vigorous in pursuit of decentralisation and local ownership if they are to create a context that is supportive of this more democratic approach to teacher development.

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